which has been rearranged as the Champions League anthem, but knew I lacked the passion to be the best in that field.

Sport was my priority, my best chance of carving out a career. Although that led to occasional friction, I was fortunate that Andrew Morris, the school's director of music, was an MCC member and an ardent cricket fan. I played in the school jazz band and sang in the choir but began to define myself by the conventions of a professional athlete.

It wasn't quite a binary, win-or-lose lifestyle, but, philosophically, my apprenticeship had begun. I was storing realities for future reference. Batting gives you nowhere to hide. You either score runs or you don't. Your actions have consequences. You must learn to live with everything that goes with that. It involves balancing satisfying moments of success with setbacks that demand urgent self-questioning.

I'd had a distinctive upbringing. The hard graft of five years in choir school meant that I lost my innocence prematurely, but also ensured that I cherished slithers of spare time. It taught me the truth of that trite assertion that, if you want something done, ask a busy man. I would eventually sacrifice teenage rites of passage such as chaotic lads' holidays to Ayia Napa or Magaluf, but I don't think I missed out on much.

My close friendships at home in Essex were usually developed in school holidays, through cricket. One in particular has provided painful perspective. I knew David Randall through the Maldon club. We opened the batting together from the age of eleven and were named in the same England development squads. Since Ravi Bopara batted at three with us for Essex, the poor guys down the order rarely needed to strap on their pads; we were dominant.

We knew David as Arkle. He scored more runs than me and Ravi but, as is often the way, he never pursued professional cricket, preferring to go to university. His death, from bowel cancer at the age of twenty-seven, hit hard, because it reminded us of the limits of mortality. It united the Maldon cricket club, and inspired the local community. The work done by the charitable foundation established in his name, in helping those with life-limiting illness, remains close to my heart.

Though our paths diverged professionally, we had remained close personally. I found boarding at Bedford a release after the slightly claustrophobic environment of the choir school, and though I was small and